

Saving North Middletown Elementary

Executive Summary • The Case Against Closure, the Case for Growth, and the Choice

Version 4.5 • August 2, 2026 • Built from public records and Open Records Requests only • Every figure sourced in the full report and reproduced as live formulas in the companion workbook at [SaveNMES.org](https://www.saveNMES.org)

WHAT HAPPENED

On July 15, 2026, a planning committee voted to label North Middletown Elementary “transitional.” That is the first step toward closing the school. The vote is advisory. The elected Board of Education decides. We checked the public records so the Board and the public can see the whole picture before any vote. Every number below is sourced in the full report and runs as a live formula in the companion workbook.

PART ONE

The case against closing NMES: four facts from the district's own documents

- **Fact one: it is the county's best elementary school.** On the state's 2024-25 tests, North Middletown ranks first among the county's four elementary schools in every tested subject, and it beats the state average in science and writing. It was a National Blue Ribbon School in 2011, one of five in Kentucky that year.
- **Fact two: it is not expensive.** On the newest state spending file (2024-25), NMES costs \$17,903 per student. The average Kentucky elementary school costs \$19,299, so NMES runs 7 percent below the state average. The district's own cost table, dated May 21, 2026, agrees: it prices the school at \$19,080 per student against a state average of \$19,020 on the same table, a gap of three tenths of one percent.
- **Fact three: closing it frees very little.** Start from everything the district spent on the school last year: \$1,285,310, from its own ledger. Almost all of it moves with the children or pays for itself. Only the building's own costs stop: \$79,211 a year if staff keep their jobs, up to \$127,039 if the building is sold. The superintendent's written response says all staff would be retained, and it prices those staff at its own \$54,479.40 loaded cost. The superintendent's \$661,139 savings claim does not survive the district's own paperwork: with staff retained and supplies moving with the kids, only \$127,039 of it remains. We priced 5,832 closure scenarios on the district's own figures. The middle case LOSES \$20,007 a year, and 55 percent of the scenarios lose money.
- **Fact four: closing it risks a lot, every year.** Under HB 563, state money follows each child to whichever district wins the family. Registered homeschooling in this county grew from 170 to 259 in five years. The state virtual academy grew from 937 to 2,412 students in two years. Every family that leaves takes about \$5,100 a year of state money with it, and the loss grows as the missing kids reach every grade:

Share who leave	Students (of 128)	Year one	Per year, full effect	Total by grade 12
10 percent	13	\$67,000	\$144,000	\$1.5 million
20 percent	26	\$133,000	\$287,000	\$3.1 million
30 percent	38	\$195,000	\$420,000	\$4.6 million
50 percent	64	\$328,000	\$713,000	\$7.7 million

The first wave is only the start: the missing kids climb one grade a year, so by year eight every grade is short and the yearly loss is more than double the first hit. The children in the building carry about \$6.2 to \$6.9 million of remaining state funding through grade 12. One in seven students at the middle and high school came through North Middletown. A family lost at kindergarten is lost for thirteen years.

The bottom line, from the two priced models: grow the school and the middle case GAINS \$141,780 a year, with not one losing scenario in 19,683. Close it and the middle case LOSES \$20,007 a year.

PART TWO

The district needs growth, not closures: three levers the board already owns

The money problem is real, and it is district-wide. The General Fund ran a \$2.65 million deficit in fiscal 2025. The district's own June 2026 ledger trends fiscal 2026 about \$1.74 million in the red: better, still red. The causes are plain. Pandemic aid ended. Funded attendance fell by about 248 once the pandemic hold-harmless ended, and the state's 2026-27 forecast puts it at 2,174, down again. The district also sweeps \$1.32 million a year of restricted building money into operations, draining the fund that should pay for buildings. And the revenue posture is unique in the region: the county's tax base grew 107.5 percent since 2012, second fastest of eight area counties, while the school levy fell 5.4 percent, the only drop among nine districts. Every neighbor's base grew too. Their boards raised rates anyway.

- **Lever one, enrollment.** Each recovered student brings about \$4,226 of state money after supplies. The pool is measured: 236 students sit in Bourbon's own homeschool files, and 450 to 550 Bourbon County Schools kids are homeschooled, in private school, or enrolled in another district, worth \$1.9 to \$2.3 million a year. Eminence Independent proved the model an hour away: it grew 35 percent in the decade Bourbon Schools shrank 10. Growth pays in every one of 19,683 priced scenarios, with a middle case of +\$141,780 a year.
- **Lever two, fixed costs.** Trim every non-teaching position by attrition: \$340,000 to \$425,000 a year. Weigh an administrative restructuring: \$224,000 to \$450,000. Smarter bus routes: \$146,000 to \$291,000 on a \$2.9 million line no routing study has ever tested. Energy contracts: \$50,000 to \$150,000. Counted once, the package is \$760,000 to \$1.3 million a year.
- **Lever three, revenue.** The rate is simply lower while the tax base more than doubled. Restoring the board's own 2018 rate brings in about \$1.7 million a year, and the rate menu beyond it reaches \$1.0 to \$2.5 million.

Together, the plan is transformative. With costs at the low end and the full restore, it clears the trending gap with about \$721,000 a year to spare: a 5 percent raise for every certified teacher and about \$35 million of building capacity, anchored on the \$32 million of bonding capacity the district's own advisor presented in June 2026, before a single leaked student comes back. Recover half the pool and the surplus reaches about \$1.9 million a year; the full pool reaches about \$3.6 million and about \$72 million of capacity. Every school stays open. To run it, the board should create three standing committees, one per lever, each reporting publicly: enrollment growth, fixed costs, and revenue. NMES volunteers stand ready to serve on all three.

THE CHOICE

Two roads, and four asks that cost nothing

Shrink to fit, or grow and thrive. On North Middletown, four asks that cost nothing:

- **One:** keep the school listed as Permanent in the facility plan; a plan commits no money, and only Permanent keeps every door open.
- **Two:** give it the four years to the next plan, with public enrollment targets and the tools to hit them, judged on results.
- **Three:** let the community fund the building's needs with grants, private money, and donated labor.
- **Four:** say publicly that the district will work to grow this school; uncertainty is its own enrollment killer.

These asks put no money at risk: if staff keep their jobs, closing frees only \$79,211 of building costs on the district's own ledger. A closed school cannot be recalled by the children it displaces. A growth plan can be measured, every year, by everyone.

The full 49-page report, the financial model with every calculation as live formulas, all archived district documents, and every prior version with its corrections are free at SaveNMES.org and in the public repository.